for the landing and take-off shots. Director Oni Sen recounts feeling surreal at the access he and cinematographer Setu had to the Nal Air Force Station in Rajasthan, which enabled them to shoot with the aircraft. To get the topography right, Sen and Setu shot at Shinkula and Baralacha in Spiti, Himachal Pradesh, after mapping the heights and distances between peaks in Kargil.

As much as scale and warfare are integral to *Operation Safed Sagar*, Sen (best known for the series *Asur*) was keen to emphasise the human stories of the men in uniform. "We tried to be true to the bonding, camaraderie and realism of relationships," he says.

But was the IAF game for the creative liberties needed to make the show engaging even as it stayed true to the events? "They [IAF] are all savvy in terms of what they watch," says Parmar, with a smile. "They do understand drama and had some suggestions which were so dramatic that we have not put them in.... It would have been stranger than fiction." Sen notes that the creativity of "the pranks" IAF members pull on each other was such that they "couldn't use them on the show".

Operation Safed Sagar doesn't mince words when it comes to the Kargil War, using the real names of India's foes across the border and laying bare the betrayal that led to the two-month conflict. It's a bold move, one that makes the show more hard-hitting. For the makers, it is all in service of presenting an accurate account of the war rooted in facts. "When there are real names being used on the IAF side, it has to be a unifier across the story," notes Bami. And reality, as they say, bites. ■

—Suhani Singh

THE RETURN OF ROMANCE

IN THE NETFLIX SERIES *MUSAFIR CAFE*, **VIKRANT MASSEY** MAKES A CASE FOR BEING THE IDEAL ROMANTIC HERO

Long before he achieved nationwide fame and subsequently a National Award for his performance in *12th Fail*, Vikrant Massey had a fandom who rooted for his turn as supportive husband in *Balika Vadhu* and as the vulnerable Veer in the romantic drama *Broken But Beautiful*. With the Netflix series *Musafir Cafe*, Massey returns to the genre to do what he loves doing on screen. "I find it endearing to open up your heart and just be," he says. "We all have a facade, our defence mechanism is so high because of fear of judgement, but life is far simpler than we think it is."

In *Musafir Cafe*, he plays Chander, a nerdy US-returned engineer who falls hard for Sudha (Vedika Pinto). Sudha has plans to move to Mumbai while Chander's dream is to own a cafe in a hill station. The lovers gradually part ways only to meet again years later, this time at his cafe in Mussoorie, which he runs with his girlfriend Preeti (Mahima Makwana). But 'has Chander moved on from his first love?' is the question *Musafir Cafe* poses.

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> **VIKRANT MASSEY**
> *Actor-producer*



HEART MATTERS Massey with Mahima Makwana in a still from the show

Massey, who co-produced the series with his wife, Sheetal Talwar, calls creator-writer Sharanya Rajgopal's script one of the "most accomplished" he has read. "I resonated with her take on life... there was depth in characterisation and world building. It's important to me that my characters have dignity and integrity, and all the more in romantic stories," he says.

For Sharanya, it's viewpoints like these that made Massey the right fit for Chander. "There was a line in the show that didn't make the cut: 'He is a green forest,'" says Sharanya of the actor. Mahima concurs. "It's his sincerity as an actor," she says. "It's so refreshing to see men be broken, beautiful partners to their girlfriend. As women, we want to see that on screen as well." ■

—Suhani Singh